

OF FEW HISTORIC FIRSTS AND MANY WHAT-IFS

Following the three historic shooting medals, the present is a happy place, worth celebrating, but it's hard not to dwell on the many frustrating

"what-could-have-beens."

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If one can look beyond the many clichés in *O Vencedor está Só*, penned by Paulo Coelho in 2008, there exists a line that is likely to stay with you: "People are never satisfied. If they have a little, they want more. If they have a lot, they still want more."

The human heart is a funny place. It never stops yearning. There are moments when you may feel your heart is full. However, before the dust can settle, you will be chasing another canon event.

This eternal pursuit of happiness gives birth to dreams that could eventually make or break you. When Manu Bhaker became India's first shooter and female athlete to strike gold at the Youth Olympic Games in 2018, the podium would have felt like home, where she belonged. As the euphoria began to subside, something inside her would have screamed in protest.

And thus started a long and arduous journey to reach the pinnacle of an Olympic sport — winning one of those hallowed discoid chunks of metal they call medals in the Summer Games.

Tokyo naturally became the first pit stop in 2020, later deferred to the following year after the coronavirus pandemic left the world in limbo. Manu and her mixed-team partner Saurabh Chaudhary entered the competition as favourites to win gold in their events, having displayed unwavering focus in ISSF (International Shooting Sport Federation) events preceding the

Olympics. But in a shocking turn of events, the Indian contingent failed to win a single medal, let alone gold.

The shockwaves left behind in the wake of the disaster had telling effects. For starters, New Zealand cricketer Jimmy Neesham's 2019 social media post saying, "Kids, don't take up sport. Take up baking or something. Die at 60 really fat and happy," went viral again. Then, Manu went into depression, Saurabh never got his form back, some shooters disappeared from the circuit, and one even went on a pilgrimage!

The Manu of yore, who once used to win medals for fun, took a lot of


India, which had failed to open its account in Tokyo 2020, finished 14th on the shooting medal tally. Going purely by count, India will take fifth place.